‘the group’s reputation for ethics and professionalism make it a first stop for foreign investors’, wrote *The Wall Street Journal*.

Calling it the ‘most significant’ initiative that the group had undertaken, Ratan ensured that the code reflected the ‘bedrock value system’ of the Tata Group. He had specifically evolved it to ensure that while the group went through dramatic changes, it would not be at the cost of its ethical standards. The code reflected the ‘pride and faith’ the Tata Group had in their ‘traditional value system’, said Ratan during his keynote address at the Code of Conduct adoption function on 18 December 1999. Through the TCoC, Ratan attempted to systematize the value systems on which the group had been built. Highlighting the two important elements of the code, ‘unity and clarity’, he explained that ‘through the adoption of a common Code of Conduct’, the conglomerate reasserted its ‘commitment to shared values and principles’ and its ‘determination to work together to increase’ their ‘impact as a Group’.

He pointed out that while everyone spoke about the ‘Tata ethos and the Tata values’, no one had really ‘attempted to codify … or specify’ them. By and large, it was simply viewed as a ‘perceived set of values’. He felt it was necessary to remind everyone what the conglomerate stood for in an ‘articulated manner’. He wanted to ensure that every Tata employee knew what conduct was expected from those who worked for the group and the ethical manner in which business should be conducted. And the TCoC endeavoured to do exactly that. He added that it also attempted to clarify certain ‘grey areas’, especially ‘in terms of conflict of interest, in terms of improper conduct etc. where individual value systems may come into being’.

Making the code one of the main pillars of the BEBP helped in promoting the Tata brand. Be it the quality of goods and services, human relations or how to treat the stakeholders, according to Ratan, ‘The code of conduct really has something to do with what we promise the consumer when we say it’s the Tata product, what stands behind it.’ According to R. Mukundan, CEO and MD of Tata Chemicals, every year, the ethics report goes to the board and the group chairman.

While the group formally implemented the TCoC in 1998, a revised version, containing twenty-five clauses, was introduced in October 2008 to accommodate the global diversity of the expanding conglomerate. Ratan’s emphasis was for Tata companies to do business ‘with a common code of